

For Their Eyes Only

By Shafi Rahman

It seems we are on the brink of becoming a secretocracy. Though months have passed since Prime Minister Manmohan Singh made a joint statement with his Pakistani counterpart Yusuf Raza Gilani at Sharm el-Sheikh in the arc lights of international diplomacy, the Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) is diligently shielding details of its file notings from a Right to Information (RTI) applicant. The Prime Minister's Office (PMO) is busy safekeeping documents on former prime minister Lal Bahadur Shastri who left behind a shining reputation, a small outstanding loan and looming questions related to the circumstances of his death. Requests for official documents—from inside details of India's wars with Pakistan and China to papers on the mole in Indira Gandhi's PMO, correspondence between former president K.R. Narayanan and former prime minister Atal Behari Vajpayee to file notings on the Ranganath Mishra Commission for religious and linguistic minorities—have been shrugged off by various ministries during the last year. In 2008, the PMO refused to give an RTI applicant details of the Law Ministry's advice on claiming Rs 100 crore compensation from Dow Chemicals for environmental remedial costs of the Bhopal Gas tragedy. The Armed Forces Tribunal has held that a former army commander had fudged documents related to the 1999 Kargil conflict, while the Army has allegedly destroyed operational details of the 1971 Indo-Pak War.

The lines are getting seriously blurred at Raisina Hill. The sun-dried babudom is busy airbrushing the facts and protecting documents of historical relevance from historians, researchers and the public, flouting both the declassification and RTI rules. They are keeping an amazing windfall of classified

documents that drop into their lap every day with the enthusiasm of a guardian angel refusing to give away his celestial map. Though the law stipulates that all files older than 25 years should be declassified, many ministries are refusing to downgrade the status of such files from 'classified' to 'declassified' and send them to the National Archives of India (NAI). While the bureaucracy and politicians cover their tracks, the nation is being denied the truth of its past.

The PMO has 28,865 classified files in its shelves, from 1947 to 2009. In 2005, it declassified only one file, two in 2006, 37 in 2007, 50 in 2008 and none in 2009. The MEA, a huge repository of classified historical information, has declassified only 121 files during the last six years. The last major declassification drive in the History Division of the Ministry of Defence happened in 1997 when it declassified the history of the Indian National Army. Nothing else has been done for five years.

Also buried in the vaults of South Block is a report on the Sino-Indian War prepared by Henderson Brooks, an Anglo-Indian officer in 1964, which took a critical view of the Indian military structure of the time and the execution of operations. When Independent MP Rajeev Chandrasekhar, through a Parliament question, asked Defence Minister A.K. Antony last year to divulge details of the report, the minister refused, saying that the contents of the report "are not only extremely sensitive but are of current operational value". Many scholars argue that the report is still kept locked up only because one of its findings was that the number of men lost to by frostbite was larger than the number of

jawans who died from Chinese bullets, an indictment of the then government.

Every time the Government plugs the flow of historical documents, it is also restricting the Indian side of the story. "When I began to do research for my first book, *The Fate of Tibet*, I went to the NAI and was told that all papers for North East Frontier Agency area (which includes Tibet) were classified after 1913. I could not believe it, I knew that most of the files were available in London (India Office Records) at Kew till 1950," says Claude Apri, French historian who has authored a number

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